Introduction

This course has to do with thinking. It is an examination of thinking in order to understand and appreciate the extent to which we think and how our values impact on who we become, what we believe, and what we do. Evaluation and generation of ideas will feature significantly as we reflect on our identity, how we should live, how we do things, and how we relate to others.

The origin of thinking

Critical and Creative Thinking belongs to a discipline known as Philosophy. It implies a way of thinking that involves examining, questioning and doubting much of what we normally take for granted. It is in this sense that the term "philosophy" itself was coined by the Greek thinker Pythagoras. The word itself means "love of wisdom". Wisdom is neither inheritable nor instantly available. It is earned through diligent and disciplined mental activity. The term and its derivatives have been translated to love of thinking. One has to set the mind in motion toward examining concepts, relating ideas, developing new concepts and seeing through and beyond mere words and facts. This is the sense in which we understand philosophy as "a reflective and reasoned attempt to infer the character and the content of the universe, taken in its entirety and as a single whole, from an observation and study of the data presented by all its aspects". (Fuller, 1955, 1).

According to Namwambah, the intellectual roots of critical and creative thinking are as old as the days of the Greek philosopher known as Socrates over 2500 years ago. He discovered that by a method of systematic probing questionings, people could not rationally justify their confident claims to knowledge. He argued that one cannot depend on those in authority to get sound knowledge and insight. He observed that a person may occupy higher leadership position yet remain deeply confused and irrational. He sought to arrest the problem by establishing the importance of asking deep questions that forces a person to think harder before accepting ideas as worthy of belief. In his analysis, he established the importance of seeking evidence, closely examining reasoning and assumptions, analysing basic concepts and seeking to understand the implications for whatever was said and done. This method graduated the name Socratic questioning which is a teaching methodology applied in Critical and Creative thinking. Socrates was followed by Plato who recorded Socrates thoughts, then Aristotle and Greek skeptics. In the Middle Ages, Critical Thinking was taken a notch higher by such thinkers such as Thomas Aquinas who wrote Suma theologia. He answered all his critics as part of his developing his skill in critical thinking. He explained that those who think critically do not always reject established beliefs. They only reject beliefs that lack reasonable foundations. During the age of European renaissance, Francis Bacon of England was concerned with the way his contemporaries misused

their minds. He acknowledged that the mind cannot safely be left to its natural tendencies. He published a book, The advancement of Learning, where he emphasized on the need to study empirically. In the process, he laid the foundation for modern science with his emphasis on the information - gathering processes.

Rene Descartes (1596 – 1650), French Philosopher father of modern and Western Philosophy followed fifty years later. Using the philosophical system of mathematical reasoning, he disregarded any knowledge without absolute certainty. He compared his philosophical method to geometry; a discipline that accepts only what is an undeniable axiom or has been rationally proven. He began by an attitude of universal doubt making sure that something is certain if it cannot be doubted. He started by doubting his own existence. He found undeniable truth in his own existence. He could doubt everything but not that the doubting subject existed. “I think, therefore I am” (Latin *cogito ergo sum*). You cannot deny the existence of “I” a “thinking thing” but the body of a philosopher can be doubted because it has not been proven.

Descartes felt that he could prove the existence of God before proving the existence of his own body. He found in his mind the idea of a “more perfect being” and since his mind could not produce such an idea, which was above itself, it must have been placed there by God. Descartes therefore, concluded that God exists. It was only then, on the basis of the existence of God, and of trust in the divine perfection, that Descartes felt free to move on to prove the existence of the world and of his own body. He wrote the second text in Critical thinking. He emphasized on the need for special systematic disciplining of the mind to guide it in thinking. He defended the need for clarity and precision.